But the Portuguese now had the key to the India passage. They returned with more ships, greater firepower and better gifts, so that when the so-called Second India Armada reached Calicut in September 1500 its admiral was able to offer the Zamorin the support of his fighting ships in his ongoing wars with his rivals up and down the coast: Cambay to the north and Cochin to the south. This secured the Portuguese a commercial treaty that allowed them to set up in Calicut a *feitoria*, or trading post – a word soon anglicised into ‘factory’. As so often in Indian history, rivalries between one kingdom and another allowed a third power to move in to its advantage – a feature of military expansion since time immemorial which for some reason has come to be seen in India as a peculiarly British vice, under the phrase ‘divide and rule’.

Such military alliances nearly always end in tears for the weaker party, and so it was here. The Portuguese seized an Arab ship being loaded with spices bound for Jeddah and the Arabs retaliated by attacking the Portuguese factory. Blaming the Zamorin for allowing the massacre that followed, the Portuguese brought all the firepower of their ships to bear on his town, killing hundreds and setting the pattern for what followed.

On 3 October 1502 Vasco da Gama, now admiral of what would become known as the notorious Fourth India Armada, came across the merchant ship *Mirim*, with several hundred Muslim pilgrims aboard. His hatred of Moors appears to us now as bordering on the psychopathic, yet it seems to have been shared by many of his Portuguese compatriots. How else to explain the gratuitous cruelty they displayed at every opportunity hereafter, beginning with that first encounter at sea when the *Mirim* was looted, primed with gunpowder and set ablaze? Twenty children were spared for conversion to Christianity.

Vasco da Gama next anchored his fleet before the harbour of Calicut and ordered the Zamorin to expel the Moors.